Aishwarya Rai has taken her husband's surname and peppers her interviews with references to her role as a wife (though she is an admittedly equal partner in her dual superstar marriage). Perhaps the weight of tradition and social mores sits on the shoulders of all women to varying degrees. And perhaps only those like Mayawati or Rai are confident or ambitious enough to try and challenge convention.

Back in the real world, though, women are seen mostly with children or doing domestic chores. Most offices, shops, restaurants, and bookstores that I visit in different cities in India are staffed by men, who also act as drivers, waiters, hotel cleaners, street stall operators, and the like. Many women find jobs as teachers in public schools, or are librarians and research scholars like the ones I met while in Calcutta, but figures from the last decade show that women represented just 19 percent of the total workforce and made far less than their male counterparts; indeed, rural Indian women make less than two dollars per day. The female labor force participation rate in India was only 28.5 percent in 2017, versus 82 percent for males.[16] So far, no Indian government has come up with a program like Japanese prime minister Shinzo Abe's "womenomics," which has aimed at increasing female representation across the board in Japan's economy. In 2018, 67 percent of Japanese women of working age were in the labor force.[17] By contrast, in 2013, India ranked 98 out of 128 countries in *The Economist*'s measure of women's economic opportunity.[18]

Yet some Indian women who are fortunate enough to get an education, who come from an established family, or who find supportive partners, have far more chances at a successful career and personal happiness than others without such advantages. At a major hotel in Delhi, I talk with Gunvanti, a twenty-six-year-old professional. Gunvanti was married only a few months ago, to a man she met and fell in love with while working at the same office. They are both Hindu but from different castes. Her widowed mother, from an elite Brahmin subcaste who served as priests for the maharaja of Jaipur, was opposed to her marrying her beau, even though he was from an aristocratic Rajput caste. Gunvanti enlisted her uncle and other male family